



*A climber for two where players bid contracts
and Aces shovel pairs and sets*

Designed by Jonathan Ratschat
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Concept

Dopplin is a two-player climbing and shedding game played with a shortened double deck.

Players lead and beat singles, pairs, sets, runs, and connected sets. There are no bombs. Instead, cards of the weakest rank can shovel an opponent's pair or set into your hand and remain on the pile as the new active play.

Before play begins, players bid for contracts that raise the stakes and set the terms of the hand: who leads, how set-aside cards enter play, and what the declarer must achieve. Victory comes from reading your hand, choosing the right contract, and knowing when to shed quickly, hold back, or shovel at the right moment.

Setup

Players: 2.

Cards: From 2 standard 54-card decks, keep the Aces, 2s, 3s, 4s, 5s, Js, Qs, and Jokers, excluding all Diamonds. This gives **46 cards**: 6 each of A, 2, 3, 4, 5, J, and Q, plus 2 Small and 2 Big Jokers. If the Jokers are not marked as Small and Big, agree before play which two are Small Jokers and which two are Big Jokers.

Deal: Deal **18 cards** to each player. Set the remaining **10 cards** aside face down, unused except as noted by certain contracts.

First bidder: Randomly choose the first bidder for the first hand. In later hands, the player with fewer points bids first. If scores are tied, the player who did not score the previous hand bids first.

Card Rank

Of the 6 Queens, the 2 Heart Queens form their own rank. The other 4 are called **ordinary Queens**.

Highest to lowest: Heart Queens > Big Jokers > Small Jokers > ordinary Queens > Jacks > 5s > 4s > 3s > 2s > Aces.

Heart Queens cannot combine with ordinary Queens. The two Heart Queens may pair with each other.

Aces are the lowest-ranked ordinary cards and also have the special shovel power.

Jokers may be played only as singles or as same-kind pairs. They cannot substitute for other cards.

Contracts

Before play, starting with the first bidder, players alternate chances to declare. A player may **pass** or declare a contract stronger than the current one. The auction ends when a player passes after a contract has been declared, when both players pass with no contract declared, or immediately when **Shutout** is declared.

If both players pass, play **Quiet**. If a contract is declared, the player who declared the final contract is the **declarer**. In every declared contract, the declarer's aim is **to shed**

out before the non-declarer. Unless a contract states otherwise, the declarer leads first and fails if the non-declarer sheds out first. Each contract changes only what is stated in its description. See **Contract Reference** for the full contract table.

Contract order: Breakaway < Forced Shovel < Buried Treasure < Red Finish < The Chase < Shutout.

Turn Flow

When **leading**, play any legal combination. You may not pass. When **responding**, either pass, play a legal combination that **beats the current play**, or **shovel** (see Shovel). If the opponent passes, the last player who played clears the pile and leads again.

The hand ends the moment a player makes their final play, or earlier through contract failure or non-declarer escape. The opponent cannot beat or shovel this final play.

Legal Plays

Play	Requirement
Single	1 card.
Pair	2 equal-rank cards. The two Heart Queens may pair. Same-kind Jokers may pair.
Set	3 to 6 equal-rank cards.
Single run	Exactly 4 or 5 consecutive singles, using only A, 2, 3, 4, and 5.
Connected sets	3+ consecutive equal-size groups: connected pairs, triples, quads, 5-, or 6-of-a-kind groups. Only A, 2, 3, 4, and 5 may be used.

Comparison: A play only beats the **same type** with matching size, length, and structure, and only if it is **strictly higher**. Equal does not beat equal. Singles, pairs, and sets compare by rank. Runs and connected sets compare by their highest card or highest group. Connected sets must match both group size and number of groups.

No bombs: There are no bombs and no cross-type beating.

Shovel

Aces have a special **shovel** power. On your turn, you may play Aces to capture the opponent's current pair or set by playing exactly one fewer Ace than the target contains cards.

Shovel play	Captures
A	A pair
A-A	A triple
A-A-A	A 4-of-a-kind
A-A-A-A	A 5-of-a-kind
A-A-A-A-A	A 6-of-a-kind

The captured cards are added to the shoveling player's hand. The played Aces stay on the pile as the current active play. Play then continues as normal: the opponent may beat the Aces, shovel them if possible, or pass.

Example: Opponent plays Q-Q-Q. You play A-A. You take Q-Q-Q into your hand. The active play is now A-A. A shovel may only capture the opponent's current play.

Limits: Shovel may capture only pairs and sets of ordinary ranks: Aces, 2s, 3s, 4s, 5s, Js, and ordinary Queens. It cannot capture Heart Queens or Jokers.

Scoring

Scoring format: Success / Failure. If the declarer succeeds, they score the first value. If they fail, the opponent scores the second value.

Contract	Score
Quiet	9
Breakaway	15 / 10
Forced Shovel	21 / 14
Buried Treasure	27 / 18
Red Finish	42 / 28
The Chase	54 / 36
Shutout	84 / 56

Card bonus: The player who scores the hand also scores 1 additional point for each card remaining in the opponent's hand, capped at the base score awarded for the hand. No card bonus is awarded for Shutout.

In **Quiet**, the first player to shed out scores 9 points plus the card bonus.

Match: Play to **150 points** for a short match, **250 points** for a longer one, or any agreed number of hands or points. A points match ends after a hand in which someone reaches the target. Poker chips make scoring convenient, but pen and paper works too.

Learning the Game

You may use the full rules from the start if you prefer. Otherwise, the steps below offer a gradual way to learn the game.

- 1. Learn the card play first.** Start with at least one hand of **Quiet**, skipping the auction. The first bidder leads, and the first player to shed out wins. Ignore scoring if you want. Focus on legal plays, beating combinations, passing, clearing the pile, and using the shovel.
- 2. Add a few contracts.** Once the basic play feels comfortable, use the auction but allow only **Breakaway**, **Buried Treasure**, and **Red Finish**. Quiet still applies whenever both players pass. These contracts introduce the core ideas without adding too many special rules.
- 3. Add the full game.** After a few hands, use the full contract list. Contracts are the heart of Dopplin, but they are easier to enjoy once both players know the basic concepts and have developed a feel for which hands are worth bidding on.

A few tips:

- Do not spend Aces too early. The shovel is often your best way back into a hand.
- Watch the opponent's hand size. As the non-declarer, you are fighting the card bonus as well as the contract.
- Before bidding, think about how you expect to finish the hand. Many contracts are won or lost in the endgame.
- Contracts involving the set-aside cards are a gamble.

They may give you exactly what you need or change your hand in ways you did not expect.

Contract Reference

Contract	Requirement
Quiet	No declarer. The first bidder leads. The first player to shed out wins.
Breakaway*	No added conditions.
Forced Shovel	Before their final play, the declarer may play Aces only to shovel, and not in any other combination, including within runs and connected sets. The declarer's final play may contain Aces in any legal combination. Whenever the declarer has a legal shovel available, they must shovel.
Buried Treasure*	Before play, reveal the top 3 set-aside cards. The non-declarer chooses either 1 or 2 of them and adds the chosen cards to their hand. The declarer takes the remaining revealed card or cards.
Red Finish*	The non-declarer leads first. The declarer's final play must contain a Heart Queen.
The Chase	Before play, the declarer takes the top 3 set-aside cards into their hand. The non-declarer leads first. The declarer must shed out before the non-declarer escapes. The non-declarer escapes the moment they have fewer than 3 cards after playing on their turn. Shoveling cannot trigger escape.
Shutout	The declarer must shed out before the non-declarer plays any card. If the non-declarer plays any card first, including a shovel, the declarer fails immediately.

** Recommended when first introducing contracts*

Design Notes and Credits

Dopplin is mainly inspired by Dalian Red 5, with additional inspiration from Big A and Dou Dizhu.

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